

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

*The Gospel of Life ~
The Gospel According to Hildegard von Bingen
September 21st, 2025*



Saint Hildegard of Bingen (1098–1179)

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
Telephone 213.385.1341 – www.FCCLA.org

The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence

Improvisation on O WALY WALY and BEECHER

Meditation on "O ignis Spiritus paracliti" (Hildegard von Bingen)

Agape (Nicholas Britnell)

Three pieces by Ramón Noble:

- Toccata
- El Flautista Alegre
- La Bamba

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Michael Lehman

Words of Gathering

Rev. Lehman & Ianthe Marini

You, O Sacred Breath, are the one whose praise echoes on high.
Your presence adorns all the earth.
You are the breeze that nurtures all things green.
You encourage blossoms to flourish with ripening fruits.

You, O Spirit, feed the purest streams.
You are the rain coming from the dew
that causes the grasses to laugh with the joy of life.
You call forth our tears, even as you yearn for the good of all.

Most royal greening verdancy, rooted in the sun,
You shine with radiant light, in this circle of earthly existence.
You shine so finely, it surpasses understanding.
You encircle us in the arms of your Mystery and make us whole. [HvB, adapted from *Viriditas*]

So may it be...
So may it be for all of us!

Please stand as you are able, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering

***Hymn of Gathering**

God, Who Stretched the Spangled Heavens

BEECHER

God, who stretched the spangled heavens infinite in time and place,
Flung the suns in burning radiance through the silent fields of space;
We, your children, in your likeness, share inventive powers with you;
Great Creator, still creating, show us what we yet may do.

We have ventured worlds undreamed of since our days of childhood;
Known the ecstasy of winging through untraveled realms of space;
Probed the secrets of the atom, yielding unimagined power,
Facing us with life's destruction or our most triumphant hour.

As each far horizon beckons, may it challenge us anew,
Children of creative purpose serving others, honoring you.
May our dreams prove rich with promise, each endeavor, well begun;
Great creator, give us guidance till our goals and yours are one.

***Prayer of Awareness**

Rev. Lehman

O Love, who abounds in all things,
from the deepest depths to the highest stars—
you are tender, wise, and strong.
You bring all creatures into life,
and breathe life itself into us.
Awaken us now to your presence,
within and around us. [HvB, adapted from *Caritas abundat*]
Amen and Amen!

***Introit**

"O Viridissima Virga"
Cathedral Choir

HILDEGARD VON BINGEN

*"O branch of freshest green, O hail! Within the windy gusts of saints upon a quest you swayed and sprouted forth.
For in you bloomed so beautiful a flow'r, whose fragrance wakened all the spices from their dried-out stupor. Then
rained the heavens dew upon the grass and all the earth was cheered, for from her womb she brought forth fruit and
for the birds up in the sky have nests in her. Then was prepared that food for humankind, the greatest joy of feasts!
O Virgin sweet, in you can ne'er fail any joy. But now, let praise ring forth unto the Highest!"*

***The Lord's Prayer**

Greyson Kentopp

*Our God...who art in heaven,
hallowed be thy Name,
thy kindom come, thy will be done,
on earth as it is in heaven.*

*Give us this day our daily bread,
and forgive us our debts,
as we forgive our debtors.
And lead us not into temptation,
but deliver us from evil.
For thine is the kindom,
and the power, and the glory,
forever. Amen.*

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Laura Vail Fregin

Glance at the sun. See the moon and the stars.
Gaze at the beauty of earth's greenings.
Now, think.
What delight God gives to humankind
with all these things.
All nature is at the disposal of humankind.
We are to work with it.
For without it, we cannot survive.

As we work and walk with each other and our earth
in the precarious, precious days,

May the Peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow.

Please be seated

Readings from the Wisdom of Our Tradition *from Sirach*

Greyson Kentopp

For these words of the ancients whose wisdom we welcome in our present,
Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People

Rev. Lehman

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts

O Greenest Branch,
you stand in beauty like the dawn.
Rejoice with us, rejoice in us,
as summer passes to autumn in this northern hemisphere,
and as winter passes to spring for our southern hemisphere friends,
and flowers rise again from the earth.

May our prayers rise, too,
as blossoms of hope,
for all who long for healing,
for all who hunger for justice,
for all who thirst for love. [HvB, adapted from *O viridissima virga*]

May it ever be so.
May it ever be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen!

Meditation Anthem

"O Felix Anima"
Cathedral Choir, Laurel Irene, Soloist

HILDEGARD VON BINGEN

"O happy soul, whose body has sprung from the earth and with this worldly pilgrimage you've trod it down: So with rationality divine—which made you as its mirror—you have been crowned."

Sermon

The Gospel According to Hildegard von Bingen

Rev. Fregin

Invitation to Generosity

Rev. Lehman

The same Love that abounds in the stars
flows through our lives.
The same greening power that awakens the earth
calls us to join in God's renewing work.
This morning, as we offer what we have,
our gifts, our resources,
our lives—
we do so for the flourishing of all creation. [HvB, adapted from *Caritas and Viriditas*]

*At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how they're given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give.
Our hospitality team will also bring baskets for your in-person gifts during the Offertory.*

Offertory

"Amen"
Cathedral Choir

KELLY MCANDLESS

"O splendidissima gemma", "O resplendent jewel" ~Hildegard of Bingen

*Doxology

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!

[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

*Prayer of Offering

Greyson Kentopp

O Living Spirit,
we offer these, our gifts:
signs of love, tokens of hope,
fruits of our labor, and expressions of our generosity.
Enliven them with your breath,
so that what we give
may anoint wounds,
awaken life,
and renew the world.
Amen and Amen.

[HvB, adapted from *Spiritus Sanctus vivificans*]

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Lehman & Rev. Fregin

Words of Blessing

Rev. Fregin

We go in the power of Eternity,
who enfolds us in love.

*We go in the illuminating life of God,
who awakens all things to life.*

We go in the Spirit's radiance,
to breathe, to shine, and to bless.

*May the greening power of God
make of our lives a garden of hope,
for the healing of the world.* [HvB, weaving *O vis aeternitatis* and *Scivias II.2*]

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

Choral Response

"O Virtus Sapientiae"
Cathedral Choir

HILDEGARD VON BINGEN

*"O strength of Wisdom who, circling, circled, enclosing all in one lifegiving path, three wings
you have: one soars to the heights, one distills its essence upon the earth, and the third is everywhere.
Praise to you, as is fitting, O Wisdom.*

*Hymn for the Journey

O Holy Spirit, Root of Life

O WALY WALY

O Holy Spirit, Root of life,
Creator, cleanser of all things,
anoint our wounds, awaken us
with lustrous movement of your wings.

Eternal Vigor, Saving One,
you free us by your living Word,
becoming flesh to wear our pain,
and all creation is restored.

O Holy Wisdom, Soaring Power,
encompass us with wings unfurled,
and carry us, encircling all,
above, below, and through the world.

-lyrics by Jean Jazen, 1991

based on writings of Hildegard of Bingen [12th century]

Please be seated for the Postlude

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence

Short Fugue in D minor (Ascribed to J.S. Bach)

Inside The Music

"I have felt joy from all of the Hildegard I've gotten to experience this month, and what I've learned about her through that process. We get a taste of her musical and poetic expression today. As a composer, she always set her own poems. They were singular expressions inspired by her divine understanding of self, creator, and the world. Her music and poetry are often described as ecstatic. I've always wondered if that's a contemporary response to how progressive her ideas remain today. Fahad recently shed some light on Hildegard's connection to Celtic Christianity, which helped that all make sense to me. Musically speaking, each of her pieces stands out as expressive and unique to itself. For a composer of monody, that's a tall task, especially in the 12th century, when expression wasn't a primary goal of ecclesiastical composers. The melody of "O Viridissima Virga" sounds like light beams gently playing through a morning mist. She wrote it in the G mixolydian mode, which to Plato, was an expression of the sacred feminine. The gentleness comes from her repeated use of the whole step interval above and below G. The confidence comes from the varied ways she leans into the first five scale degrees. In most instances of this scalar motive, she skips the second scale degree that is part of the gentleness motive as she climbs the scale. As the scale descends, she uses a number of different approaches, giving each phrase a different expressive voice. In "O Felix Anima" she demonstrates her understanding of divinity in all beings. She speaks to the soul, describing its journey as it becomes one with an earthly body. She wrote this one in E phrygian mode, which Plato said was a mode for peace and reflection. The phrygian mode has lowered second and sixth scale degrees, which gives it a delicious biting quality when it approaches the final tone and the all-important fifth. She uses these lowered seconds and sixths to define each phrase. The lowered second tends to be used at the beginning and end of phrases, and the lowered sixth in the middle of phrases. They have a way of shocking the air into reflection. The melody of this chant is surprisingly contained compared to some of her other ones. There are only a couple of scale runs, and never a full octave or fifth run. Those two longer scale expressions make big, forward statements. Their absence shows how carefully she is treating this moment, and how precious she considers the idea of divinity inhabiting humanity. By contrast, "O Virtus Sapientiae" has multiple scalar expressions. Also in E phrygian, she largely avoids the lowered second and sixth scale degrees that are so structural in "O Felix Anima." The scales all move from high to low as wisdom's encircling power comes down to humanity to guide and energize our experiences. Each one feels like the culmination of energy that flow and find a home at the bottom of the scale. To our ears, it's often hard to hear the subtle richness of monodic chant. Hildegard's expressive output teaches us how much emotional and spiritual richness can live within the simplicity of 8 notes. Her poetry and music continue to inspire composers today, as can be seen in McCandless' "Amen," that contains a poetic reference to Hildegard as a way of celebrating the sacredness of all beings." – Dr. David Harris